THE BIG STORY

AGNIPATH SCHEME

Just two years ago, the Indian Army, which has a strength of 1.2 million personnel, crossed a major milestone: it became the world's largest ground force. Yet, there was no cause to celebrate. It achieved that distinction because India's arch-rival, China, had decided to cut its two million-strong land-based People's Liberation Army (PLA) by about 50 per cent. Significantly, the Chinese government didn't cite budgetary constraints—in terms of military spend, China is second only to the US and its expenditure is more than three times India's. Instead, Beijing said, their focus had shifted to building their air force and navy as well as investing in high technology to fortify their overall defence capability. More recently, the US, which despite its superpower status has an active armed force of 485,000, or less than half the size of India's, decided it would trim it further by 12,000 to enhance quality. Both these countries faced little opposition in pushing through these reforms.

So, when the Modi government introduced Agnipath (Path of Fire), a "transformative recruitment scheme" to improve the battle readiness of the Indian armed forces by infusing young blood, officials did not expect the fiery resistance to it. Nationwide mayhem ensued for several days, as angry youth torched rail coaches and other public property across states. The agitation threatened to grow as the farmers' protests over the central government's agriculture reforms agenda had earlier, eventually torpedoing that whole exercise.

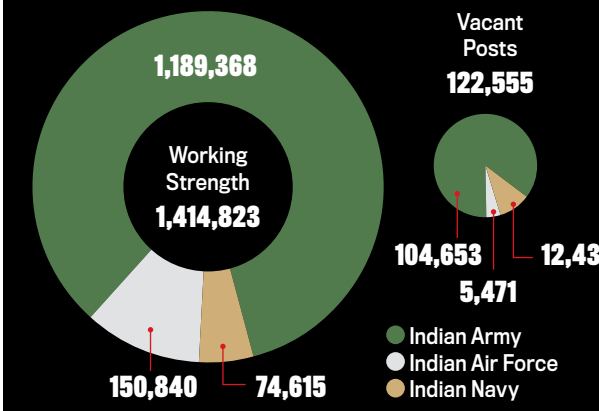
To avoid a re-enactment of that scenario, the defence ministry was quick to address some of the grievances and concerns expressed by both the agitators and a sizeable section of ex-servicemen opposed to the scheme. Simultaneously, the

RIGHT-SIZING THE ARMY

The Indian army needs to be trimmed urgently to lower the average age of its fighting force and make it a youthful, tech-savvy fighting machine

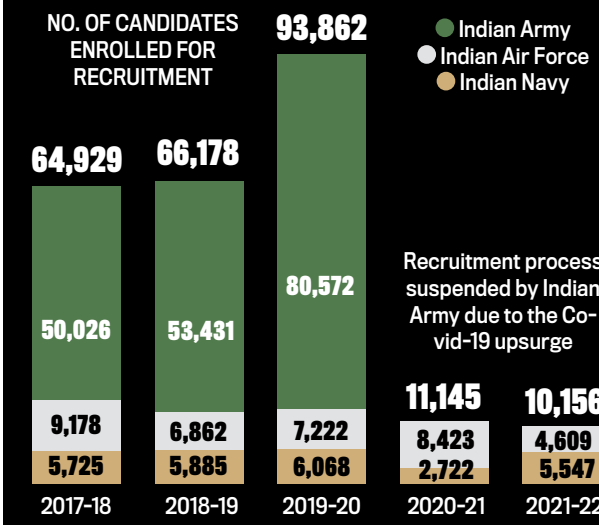
A BLOATED FORCE

Among the forces, the army employs the maximum number of people



HIT BY THE PANDEMIC

Attracting the largest no. of applicants, recruitment in the army bore the brunt



Graphics by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY